

Political ambition

Kennedy was born into an Irish-Catholic family in Brookline, Massachusetts. His father, Joseph, an ambitious businessman and diplomat, intended that his eldest son, Joe Kennedy Jr., would translate the family's wealth into political power. When Joe Jr. was killed in World War II that role passed to John.

A Harvard graduate and a hero of the naval war in the Pacific, Kennedy entered Congress as a Democrat in 1946 and became a senator at the age of 35. His marriage to the glamorous Jacqueline Bouvier confirmed the image of unstoppable success. However, the young senator had severe back pain and a hormonal disorder known as Addison's disease. The state of his health, which required operations and treatment with steroids, was successfully kept secret from the public, as were his extramarital affairs.



On the home front

In August 1963, Black Americans marched on Washington, D.C., and demanded an end to discrimination. Kennedy advanced cautiously on civil rights but laid the foundation for legislative changes that took place after his death.

World view

Kennedy's narrow victory over the far more experienced Republican candidate Richard Nixon in the 1960 presidential election was a triumph of image over substance. However, Kennedy's performance as president in troubled times earned him enduring respect. As well as facing pressing domestic issues, notably the Civil Rights Movement and the activities of organized crime, Kennedy confronted challenges on the world stage. Having criticized the previous Republican administration for allowing the Soviet Union to gain the advantage in the Cold War, he was committed to taking a tough line on the containment of communism. On the other hand, he understood the risks of nuclear war and hoped to